

PSY405 - Lesson 30

HENRY MURRAY'S PERSONOLOGY

What is Personology?

Personology is a term used by **Henry Murray** to mean:

| The scientific study of the whole person in their full complexity over time.

In plain English:

Murray believed that you **cannot understand a person by one test, one trait, or one moment.**

You must study:

- Their **life history**
- Their **motivations**
- Their **unconscious forces**
- Their **environment**
- Their **future goals**

👉 Personology = **"Let's understand the entire person, not just pieces."**

Murray's View of Personality

Murray described personality using **five important ideas**:

1. Personality is an abstraction

Definition:

An **abstraction** is a theoretical idea—not something you can directly see or touch.

Explanation:

You cannot see personality like you see height or weight.

You **infer** personality from behavior.

Example:

If someone consistently plans well, leads others, and solves problems:

➡ You say they have a *strong leadership personality*

But leadership itself is an **idea**, not a physical object.

2. Personality refers to a series of events across a lifetime

Explanation:

Personality develops and shows itself **from childhood to adulthood**, not in one moment.

Example:

A TV producer:

- Childhood: curious, imaginative
- Youth: learns media skills
- Adulthood: manages productions

➡ Personality unfolds **over time**

3. Personality shows unique, recurring, and enduring patterns

Let's break this down:

- **Novel** → different from others
- **Unique** → special to one person
- **Recurrent** → repeats again and again
- **Enduring** → lasts over time

Example:

If a person always:

- Plans ahead
- Takes responsibility
- Leads teams

➡ That is a **stable personality pattern**

4. Personality is located in the brain

Explanation:

Personality is rooted in **brain processes** like:

- Imagination
- Perception
- Thinking
- Memory

🧠 Personality is **psychological**, but it has a **biological base**.

5. Functions of personality

Personality helps a person to:

1. **Reduce conflicts**
2. **Satisfy needs**
3. **Plan for future goals**

Example:

A producer:

- Manages conflicts in a team
 - Fulfills need for achievement
 - Plans future TV projects
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Core Concepts in Murray's Theory

Now let's go through each **core concept**, one by one.

1 Definition of Personality (Murray)

Murray gave many definitions, but all had **three common elements**:

1. Personality is **abstract**
2. Personality includes **personal history**
3. Personality is linked to **physiological (brain) processes**

👉 Personality = **History + Brain + Motivation**

2 Proceedings and Serials

Proceedings

Definition:

Short-term interactions involving behavior.

Example:

- A conversation
 - A conflict
 - A decision-making moment
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Serials

Definition:

Long-term behavior patterns over extended periods.

Example:

- Marriage
- Career
- Long friendship

➡ Proceedings are **short scenes**

➡ Serials are **full movies of life**

3 Serial Programs and Schedules

Serial Programs

Definition:

Long-term plans broken into **sub-goals**.

Example:

Ambreen wants to become a doctor:

- Finish school
 - Enter medical college
 - Complete MBBS
 - Specialization
-

Schedules

Definition:

Plans that **reduce conflict between competing needs**.

Example:

Balancing:

- Study
- Family
- Rest

Good schedules = fewer inner conflicts

4 Ability and Achievement

Murray believed **ability and achievement** are central to personality.

Ability:

What a person *can do*

Achievement:

What a person *actually does*

He frequently studied:

- Leadership
- Competence
- Success

Dynamics of Personality (MOST IMPORTANT PART)

Murray's theory is mainly about **motivation**.

| "To understand a person, understand what drives them."

NEED (Central Concept)

Definition of Need:

A **need** is a **psychological force in the brain** that:

- Directs attention
- Organizes perception
- Motivates behavior
- Pushes a person toward satisfaction

In plain English:

A need is **something inside you that pushes you to act**.

Example:

Hunger → food

Need for achievement → success

Need for love → relationships

2 Types of Needs

A. Primary vs Secondary Needs

Type	Meaning	Examples
Primary (Viscero-genic)	Biological	Hunger, thirst, sex
Secondary (Psycho-genic)	Psychological	Achievement, dominance

B. Overt vs Covert Needs

Type	Meaning	Example
Overt	Openly expressed	Asking for promotion
Covert	Hidden/repressed	Secret jealousy

Covert needs often appear in **dreams and fantasies**.

C. Focal vs Diffuse Needs

Type	Meaning
Focal	Directed toward specific objects
Diffuse	Broad, general

⚠ Fixation = unhealthy attachment to one object

⚠ Too much shifting = also unhealthy

D. Proactive vs Reactive Needs

Type	Meaning
Proactive	Internally driven
Reactive	Triggered by environment

Example:

- Proactive: Starting a project yourself
- Reactive: Responding to criticism

E. Process, Modal, and Effect Needs

Type	Meaning	Example
Process	Doing for enjoyment	Drawing for fun
Modal	Doing well	Perfect handwriting
Effect	Result-focused	Getting a degree

3 Interrelation of Needs

Needs **interact**, **conflict**, and **combine**.

◆ Prepotent Needs

Strong needs (hunger, pain) dominate weaker ones.

◆ Fusion of Needs

One action satisfies multiple needs.

◆ Subsidiation

One need serves another.

Example:

Aggression → helps achievement

4 Levels of Analysis

Need vs Aim

Concept	Meaning
Need	General motivation

Concept	Meaning
Aim	Specific goal

Example:

Need for dominance → Aim: become mayor

Cathexis (Freud's term)

Definition:

Emotional energy attached to an object.

Murray said:

"You can understand personality by seeing what objects a person invests emotion in."

Murray's View on Unconscious & Childhood

- Behavior is influenced by **unconscious forces**
- Childhood experiences matter
- But later Murray emphasized **creativity and imagination**

👉 Healthy personality = **creative expression**

Research Methods Used by Murray

1. Intensive study of small samples
 2. Diagnostic councils
 3. Personality tests (e.g., TAT)
 4. Representative studies
 5. Current research
 6. McClelland's work on social motives
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Biographical Sketch (Short & Clear)

- Born: **1893, New York**
 - Education: **Harvard**
 - PhD in **Biochemistry**
 - Influenced by **Carl Jung**
 - Shifted to Psychology
 - Developed **Personology**
 - Died: **1988 (Age 95)**
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SUMMARY

- Personology = **study of whole person**
- Personality = **abstract, lifelong, brain-based**
- Motivation is central
- Needs drive behavior
- Environment (press) interacts with needs
- Personality is **unique, dynamic, and goal-directed**

Short-Question Answers

Q1: What is Personology according to Henry Murray?

Answer:

Personology is the scientific study of the whole person, considering their **life history, personality traits, motives, needs, and environment**, over time. It focuses on understanding a person in **full complexity** rather than isolated aspects. Murray emphasized that personality must be understood in terms of both **biological and psychological processes** as well as **motivational dynamics**.

Explanation:

Murray believed that a person cannot be understood by a single behavior, test, or moment. **Personology studies the patterns of thoughts, emotions, and behaviors across a person's life.** It integrates both conscious and unconscious factors, as well as interactions with the environment (press).

Example:

Studying a TV producer's life:

- Childhood curiosity → youth education → adulthood leadership
- Murray would consider **all stages** to understand the personality.

Tips:

- Remember: **"Whole person, whole life, whole environment."**
 - Think of personology as **a full movie**, not a single scene.
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Q2: How did Murray define personality?

Answer:

Murray defined personality as an **abstract, dynamic construct** that develops over time, reflects **unique and recurring behavior patterns**, and has a **biological basis** in the brain. Personality functions to **reduce conflicts, satisfy needs, and plan for future goals.**

Explanation:

- **Abstract:** Personality is a theoretical idea inferred from behavior.
- **Dynamic:** It changes yet maintains patterns.
- **Biological basis:** Brain processes like imagination and perception support personality.
- **Function:** Personality helps humans manage life challenges and plan their future.

Example:

A producer:

- Abstract → cannot see personality, only infer it

- Lifetime → childhood creativity → adult planning
- Brain-based → imagination, problem-solving
- Function → plans productions, solves conflicts in team

Tips:

- Connect **abstraction** → **brain** → **function**.
 - Remember: Personality is like a **toolbox** your brain uses to navigate life.
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Q3: What are proceedings and serials?

Answer:

- **Proceedings:** Short-term behavioral interactions involving a person and their environment (object or other person).
- **Serials:** Long-term patterns or sequences of behavior extending over months or years, such as careers, marriages, or friendships.

Explanation:

- Proceedings = **small scenes in life**
- Serials = **full story arcs**

Both are used to understand how personality unfolds over time.

Example:

- Proceeding: A conversation with a colleague
- Serial: A career as a doctor spanning 20 years

Tips:

- Think: **Proceedings = moments; Serials = lifetime story**
 - Exams often ask for difference → link with **short-term vs long-term behavior**.
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Q4: What are serial programs and schedules?

Answer:

- **Serial programs:** Long-term goals divided into **sub-goals** that guide behavior toward achievement.
- **Schedules:** Plans designed to **reduce conflicts between competing needs** and efficiently manage behavior.

Explanation:

Humans rarely achieve goals instantly; they break them into **smaller, manageable steps** (serial programs). Schedules are **behavioral strategies** to balance different needs (e.g., study, work, rest) without causing inner conflict.

Example:

Ambreen wants to become a doctor:

- Serial program → finish school → enter medical college → complete MBBS
- Schedule → study timetable balancing family, health, and learning

Tips:

- Serial programs → **what you want to achieve**
- Schedules → **how you manage competing needs**

Q5: What is the role of ability and achievement in personality?

Answer:

Ability and achievement are central to personality. **Ability** refers to a person's potential to perform tasks, while **achievement** refers to the actual completion of goals. Murray studied both to understand how **talent, effort, and motivation** interact in shaping behavior.

Explanation:

- **Ability:** Skills or talents a person can use
- **Achievement:** How those skills are applied to reach goals
- Both are influenced by childhood experiences, motivation, and personality structure.

Example:

A student with excellent writing skills (ability) who publishes articles (achievement) demonstrates personality traits like **creativity, persistence, and motivation**.

Tips:

- Exams may ask: "Difference between ability and achievement" → **ability = potential, achievement = result**.
 - Link to personality motivation: "What a person *can do* vs what they *actually do*."
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Q6: What is a need according to Murray?

Answer:

A need is a **psychological force** in the brain that motivates behavior to reduce tension, satisfy desires, and achieve goals. Needs may arise from internal biological processes or external environmental factors (press). They influence perception, thinking, emotions, and action.

Explanation:

- Needs are **forces inside us** that make us act.
- They can be conscious (overt) or unconscious (covert).
- They shape long-term personality development and moment-to-moment behavior.

Example:

- Hunger → need for food → action: eat
- Desire for achievement → need → study, work hard

Tips:

- Think: **Need = internal motivation**
 - Key concept → motivational psychology is central in Murray's theory.
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Q7: What are the types of needs?

Answer:

1. **Primary (Viscerogenic) vs Secondary (Psychogenic)**

- Primary: biological (food, water, sex)
- Secondary: psychological (achievement, dominance, recognition)

2. **Overt vs Covert**

- Overt: openly expressed
- Covert: hidden, in fantasies or dreams

3. **Focal vs Diffuse**

- Focal: directed at specific objects
- Diffuse: general, applies to many situations

4. **Proactive vs Reactive**

- Proactive: internally generated, spontaneous
- Reactive: triggered by environment

5. **Process activity, Modal, Effect needs**

- Process: doing for fun
- Modal: doing with quality/perfection
- Effect: result-oriented

Explanation:

- Needs differ by **origin, expression, focus, and purpose**
- Murray used these distinctions to map how **motivation drives behavior**.

Example:

- Secondary covert need → secretly wanting recognition
- Diffuse need → desire to help anyone in need, not a specific person
- Modal need → performing music perfectly for satisfaction

Tips:

- Exams may give examples → identify type of need.
- Tip mnemonic: **P-FORM** → Primary, Focal, Overt, Reactive, Modal.

Q8: How do needs interrelate?

Answer:

Needs interact, conflict, or support each other.

- **Prepotent need:** dominates others (e.g., hunger)
- **Fusion of needs:** one action satisfies multiple needs
- **Subsidiation:** one need serves another

Explanation:

- Needs are rarely isolated.
- Strong needs (like hunger, pain) usually take precedence.
- Some actions can satisfy multiple needs (fusion).
- Some needs are instrumental to other needs (subsidiation).

Example:

Aggressive behavior (subsidiary) → helps gain achievement (dominant need).

Studying hard → satisfies both achievement and parental approval.

Tips:

- Remember: **prepotent → dominant, fusion → multi-need, subsidiary → serving another**

Q9: What is the difference between Need and Aim?

Answer:

- **Need:** General psychological drive (e.g., desire for dominance)
- **Aim:** Specific goal reflecting the need (e.g., become mayor)

Explanation:

Needs are **broad motivations**, aims are **concrete targets**.

Understanding both shows **how general motivations translate into specific actions**.

Example:

- Need: Need for recognition
- Aim: Win an award at work

Tips:

- Use this formula: **Need → Aim → Action**
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Q10: What is Cathexis?**Answer:**

Cathexis is the **emotional energy attached to objects, people, or ideas** that evokes need satisfaction. Murray used this concept to study personality by examining which objects or goals a person invests emotion in.

Explanation:

- Positive cathexis → attraction to an object
- Negative cathexis → repulsion from an object
- Reveals personality structure and social preferences

Example:

- Strong cathexis to family → acts to protect family
- Cathexis to career → motivated to achieve work goals

Tips:

- Think: **Cathexis = emotional investment → reveals personality priorities**

MCQs

1. True/False MCQs

Q1: Personology studies only observable behavior, not life history or unconscious motives.

- A) True

- B) False

Answer: B) False

Explanation: Personology studies the **whole person**, including unconscious motives, needs, and life history—not just observable behavior.

Q2: According to Murray, personality functions include reducing conflicts, satisfying needs, and planning for future goals.

- A) True
- B) False

Answer: A) True

Explanation: Murray explicitly emphasized that **personality helps manage inner conflicts, meet needs, and guide future behavior**.

Q3: Primary needs are psychological and secondary needs are biological.

- A) True
- B) False

Answer: B) False

Explanation: Primary (viscerogenic) needs are **biological** (food, water), and secondary (psychogenic) needs are **psychological** (achievement, recognition).

Q4: Overt needs are expressed openly while covert needs are usually expressed in fantasies or dreams.

- A) True
- B) False

Answer: A) True

Explanation: Overt needs manifest in **visible behavior**, whereas covert needs are **hidden or repressed**.

Q5: A serial refers to a short interaction, while proceedings are long-term life patterns.

- A) True

- B) False

Answer: B) False

Explanation: **Proceedings** = short-term interactions, **Serials** = long-term patterns (career, marriage).

2. Conceptual MCQs

Q6: Which of the following best describes a "need" according to Murray?

- A) A simple desire without motivational impact
- B) A psychological force that motivates behavior to reduce tension and satisfy desires
- C) A temporary feeling unrelated to personality
- D) A fixed trait that cannot change

Answer: B) A psychological force that motivates behavior to reduce tension and satisfy desires

Explanation: Needs are **motivational forces** that influence perception, emotion, and action, driving behavior toward satisfaction.

Q7: Which of the following is an example of a proactive need?

- A) Feeling hungry and eating a sandwich
- B) Choosing to start a painting project because of internal desire
- C) Responding to a teacher's question in class
- D) Avoiding a dangerous street after seeing a warning sign

Answer: B) Choosing to start a painting project because of internal desire

Explanation: **Proactive needs** arise from **internal motivation**, while reactive needs respond to environmental stimuli.

Q8: What does "subsidiation of needs" mean?

- A) Two needs conflict and cancel each other
- B) One need serves as a means to satisfy another dominant need

- C) Needs operate independently
- D) Needs merge into one large goal

Answer: B) One need serves as a means to satisfy another dominant need

Explanation: Subsidiation refers to a **subsidiary need supporting a dominant need**, e.g., aggression used to achieve recognition.

Q9: In Murray's theory, a focal need is:

- A) Directed at a specific object
- B) General and broad
- C) Always subconscious
- D) Always biological

Answer: A) Directed at a specific object

Explanation: Focal needs are **object-specific**, while diffuse needs are **generalized**.

Q10: Which of the following illustrates fusion of needs?

- A) Studying hard satisfies both achievement and parental approval
- B) Hunger preventing other needs from acting
- C) Ignoring personal goals due to fatigue
- D) A fixed need for a single object

Answer: A) Studying hard satisfies both achievement and parental approval

Explanation: Fusion occurs when **one action satisfies multiple needs simultaneously**.

3. Situational MCQs

Q11: Ambreen wants to become a doctor. She creates a plan: finish school → medical college → MBBS → specialization. This plan is an example of:

- A) Serial programs
- B) Schedules

- C) Prepotent needs
- D) Subsidiation

Answer: A) Serial programs

Explanation: Serial programs are **long-term goals broken into sub-goals** to achieve a larger aim.

Q12: A person feels aggressive at work, but the aggression is mainly used to outperform a colleague and gain promotion. This is an example of:

- A) Fusion of needs
- B) Subsidiation
- C) Prepotent need
- D) Modal need

Answer: B) Subsidiation

Explanation: Aggression (subsidiary need) is used instrumentally to satisfy achievement (dominant need).

Q13: Sameer wants recognition and also to help his friends. By giving a presentation, he both impresses his teacher and helps classmates understand the topic. This is an example of:

- A) Prepotent need
- B) Fusion of needs
- C) Reactive need
- D) Focal need

Answer: B) Fusion of needs

Explanation: **One action satisfies multiple needs simultaneously** (achievement + helping others).

Q14: A student keeps daydreaming about secretly becoming famous, but doesn't take action publicly. This represents:

- A) Overt need

- B) Covert need
- C) Primary need
- D) Focal need

Answer: B) Covert need

Explanation: Covert needs are **hidden or repressed**, often expressed in fantasies rather than actions.

Q15: A person feels an intense need to dominate (general motivation) and sets a goal to become mayor. According to Murray, the **need** is _____ and the **goal** is _____.

- A) Aim; need
- B) Need; aim
- C) Prepotent; fusion
- D) Focal; diffuse

Answer: B) Need; aim

Explanation: The **need** is the broad motivation, and the **aim** is the specific goal reflecting that need.

Cheat Sheet

1 Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition	Keywords/Memory Hook	Example
Personology	Study of the whole person in full complexity	Whole person, life story	Studying a producer from childhood to adulthood
Personality	Abstract, dynamic patterns of behavior, brain-based , lifelong	Abstract, unique, enduring	Leadership, creativity, problem-solving

Term	Definition	Keywords/Memory Hook	Example
Proceedings	Short-term interactions or behaviors	Moments, small scenes	A conversation with a friend
Serials	Long-term behavior patterns	Life story, long-term	Career, marriage
Serial Programs	Long-term goals broken into sub-goals	Step-by-step plan	Becoming a doctor → finish school → med college → MBBS
Schedules	Plans to reduce conflict among needs	Conflict management	Balancing study and family time
Need	Psychological force motivating behavior	Motivation, tension reduction	Hunger, achievement
Press	Environmental factor influencing need	Environment trigger	Rewarding or threatening situations
Prepotent Need	Dominant need that overrides others	Strongest need	Hunger prevents other actions
Fusion of Needs	One action satisfies multiple needs	Multi-need	Studying → satisfies achievement + parental approval
Subsidiation	One need serves another	Supporting need	Aggression used to achieve recognition
Overt Need	Openly expressed	Visible	Asking for promotion
Covert Need	Hidden or repressed	Hidden, fantasy	Daydreaming about fame
Focal Need	Directed at a specific object	Object-specific	Desire to marry one person
Diffuse Need	General, applies broadly	Broad	Desire to help anyone in need
Proactive Need	Internally generated	Self-started	Choosing to paint for fun
Reactive Need	Triggered by environment	Response-driven	Answering a teacher's question

Term	Definition	Keywords/Memory Hook	Example
Process Activity	Doing for the sake of doing	Enjoyment	Drawing for fun
Modal Need	Doing with quality/perfection	Excellence	Playing piano perfectly
Effect Need	Goal/result-oriented	Outcome	Getting a degree
Aim	Specific goal expressing a need	Goal-directed	Become mayor (need = dominance)
Cathexis	Emotional energy attached to objects	Emotional investment	Loving family → acts to protect them

2 Types of Needs – Table with Mnemonics

Type	Description	Example	Mnemonic
Primary (Viscerogenic)	Biological needs	Hunger, thirst	P = Physical
Secondary (Psychogenic)	Psychological needs	Achievement, recognition	S = Social
Overt	Openly expressed	Asking for promotion	O = Observable
Covert	Hidden, fantasy	Secret jealousy	C = Concealed
Focal	Object-specific	Desire to marry	F = Focused
Diffuse	Broad/general	Helping anyone	D = Diffuse
Proactive	Internal drive	Painting for fun	P = Personal
Reactive	Environmental trigger	Responding to criticism	R = Response
Process	Doing for fun	Playing piano casually	P = Pleasure
Modal	Doing with quality	Perfect handwriting	M = Mastery
Effect	Goal-oriented	Getting a degree	E = End result

Memory Hook:

“Primary Social Overt Covert Focused Diffuse Personal Response Pleasure Mastery End”

(P-S-O-C-F-D-P-R-P-M-E) → Helps recall **all types of needs**.

3 Personality Functions

1. **Reduce conflicts** → balance needs
2. **Satisfy individual needs** → achievement, survival, social approval
3. **Plan for future goals** → serial programs and schedules

Example:

A TV producer balances team conflicts, achieves goals, and plans future productions.

Memory Hook: "Conflicts → Needs → Goals"

4 Serial Programs vs Schedules

Concept	Definition	Example	Tip
Serial Program	Long-term goal broken into sub-goals	Become a doctor → MBBS → specialization	Think roadmap
Schedule	Plan to reduce conflicts among needs	Study timetable + family + health	Think calendar/time-management

5 Interrelation of Needs – Table

Concept	Meaning	Example
Prepotent	Dominant need that overrides others	Hunger > desire to watch TV
Fusion	One action satisfies multiple needs	Studying → achievement + parental approval
Subsidiation	One need serves another	Aggression → helps gain recognition

Mnemonic: "P-F-S = Prepotent, Fusion, Subsidiation" → Helps remember need interactions.

6 Levels of Analysis

Concept	Definition	Example
Need	General motivation	Dominance, achievement
Aim	Specific goal reflecting need	Become mayor (dominance)
Cathexis	Emotional attachment to object	Family, career, hobbies

Tip:

Think: **Need → Aim → Action → Emotional energy (Cathexis)**

7 Dynamics of Personality – Summary

- **Motivation-centered** → personality is shaped by needs
- **Tension Reduction** → needs create tension, action reduces it
- **Thema / Unity-Thema** → recurring themes in a person's behavior
- **Uniqueness** → no two personalities are identical
- **Unconscious processes** → covert needs, fantasies
- **Socialization** → environment shapes how needs are expressed

Memory Hook: "Motivation, Tension, Theme, Unique, Unconscious, Social" → M-T-T-U-U-S

8 Murray's Research Methods

Method	Description	Example
Intensive Study	Small number of subjects, deep study	Studying 11 individuals intensively
Diagnostic Council	Expert analysis of personality	Panel evaluates patient behaviors
Instruments	Personality tests	TAT (Thematic Apperception Test)
Representative Studies	Larger populations	Surveys, sample studies
Current Research	Contemporary studies	Social motives, achievement

Method	Description	Example
McClelland	Social motives	Studied need for achievement, affiliation, power

9 Examples

Concept	Example
Overt Need	Asking a teacher for help
Covert Need	Daydreaming about fame
Prepotent Need	Hunger before work motivation
Fusion	Studying → satisfies achievement + parental approval
Subsidiation	Aggression used to gain recognition
Process Need	Drawing for fun
Modal Need	Performing piano piece perfectly
Effect Need	Graduating from university

1. **Types of Needs:** P-S-O-C-F-D-P-R-P-M-E → Primary, Secondary, Overt, Covert, Focal, Diffuse, Proactive, Reactive, Process, Modal, Effect
2. **Need Interrelation:** P-F-S → Prepotent, Fusion, Subsidiation
3. **Personality Functions:** C-N-G → Conflicts, Needs, Goals
4. **Personality Dynamics:** M-T-T-U-U-S → Motivation, Tension, Theme, Unique, Unconscious, Social
5. **Aim vs Need:** Need = general motivation, Aim = specific goal
6. **Serial Programs vs Schedules:** Roadmap vs Calendar